

Figure 7: S. Somasundara Bharati

The induction of Gurunathaiyar, whom we encountered in the first chapter as a policeman victimized by D.G. Waller for his Swadeshi leanings, was yet another asset. Given that even his higher officers described him as ‘a very able detective’, his police training and connections helped VOC to engage with a hostile government. Even though he was appointed cargo superintendent (on a monthly salary of Rs 60) only in January 1908—on his resignation as head constable—his association with VOC and Swadeshi politics predated his formal appointment as he was on leave from his police job most of the time.[11]

More information on the people who were hired for SSNCo is hard to come by. One particular case comes to light due to the peculiar circumstances surrounding it. C. Thambusami Pillai, a Christian Vellalar in his late twenties, was recruited in early 1907 only to be poached by BI. A year later, he deposed as a prosecution witness against VOC, filing some correspondence that was placed as exhibits in the case. It is from these letters that we are able to reconstruct the story.[12]

On 30 January 1907, C. Thambusami Pillai, identifying himself as the sub-editor of *People’s Guardian,* Tirunelveli, and signing himself as ‘your sincere admirer’, wrote to VOC who was then in Bombay busy with the